Compendium of the Reality of the Torma

Balitattvasaṃgraha · Toh 1281 · Derge Tengyur
གཏོར་མའི་དེ་ཁོ་ནོ་ཉིད་བསྡུ་པ

The Compendium of the Reality of the Torma, known in Sanskrit as the Balitattvasaṃgraha and in Tibetan as Gtor ma'i de kho na nyid bsdus pa, is a brief versified ritual manual attributed in its colophon to the master Dharmāpaka. It teaches how to offer a torma, a ritual cake presented to deities and spirits, within the framework of the generation stage: the practitioner visualizes a triangular source of phenomena and lotus seats arranged in three tiers, generates the deities of the body, speech and mind families together with their consorts, gathers all classes of beings into them, invites and empowers the wisdom deities, makes offerings, and finally blesses the torma and presents it with an offering mantra. It is Toh 1281 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of tantra commentaries, among the short practical ritual works composed by Indian masters to help practitioners carry out tantric rites.

In Sanskrit: baliṃ tattva saṃgraha. In Tibetan: Compendium of the Reality of the Torma.

Homage to the one endowed with wisdom.

To the bodhisattvas of great renown
who dwell in the abodes and on the grounds,
and to the siddhas, I bow down,
and I shall explain the reality of the torma.

Through the generation stage, generate mindfulness of the deity.
In front, abiding in the middle of the sky,
imagine a source of phenomena shaped like the letter E,
and within it an eight-petaled lotus:
these are the seats of the deities above, below and in the center,
in three tiers, as is fitting,
each distinguished by its own color;
above and below are the eight protectors of the directions.

At the crown, the heart and the throat,
set out the three syllables, each in its place.
From them white light streams forth.
The gods of formless existence and the rest,

down to the gods of the Four Great Kings,
are gathered in by the light and made one.
That becomes the syllable itself,
and from the syllable comes the sign.
From its complete transformation arises
the very nature of the Vajra of Body,
white in color, with the right leg extended,
holding on the right a vajra and bell,
seated together with the goddess Locanā.

From the syllable at the heart, as before,
send forth the syllables of the mantra,
and gather the ten protectors of the directions and the fathers and mothers
into a ball of light.
From that, one's own seed syllable
should be clearly seen as the sign.
From that very sign comes the deity's form:
the Vajra of Mind, blue in color,
his hand emblems the same as the Vajra of Body's,
the right leg extended, upon a lotus seat,
seated together with Māmakī,
who closely resembles the Vajra of Mind.

Humans upon the earth, nāgas below the earth,
animals, hungry ghosts and hell beings:
light rays stream forth from a,
and as they become one, imagine the source of phenomena.
Red in color, four-armed,
holding as hand emblems the bajra ghaṇṭe,
in nondual union with Pāṇḍaravāsinī,
meditate on Padmanarteśvara.

Having thus imagined all sentient beings
within the source of phenomena as the three families in actuality,
then from one's own throat and the other places,
from the syllables hūṃ and the rest, each in turn,
with jaḥ hūṃ baṃ hoḥ, by the four goddesses
beginning with Aṅkuśā, the Hook,
summon the buddhas of the three families, the Permanent One and the rest,

and dissolve them into the images,
so that, like water poured into water,
they become one, without any difference.

From the light rays of the seed syllable at one's own heart
send forth goddesses, and by them
confer empowerment at the crown with vases.
The deities above, who are white,
are crowned with the Permanent One as their head ornament;
the deities in the center with the seal of mind;
the deities below with the seal of speech.

Having thus imagined the three families in actuality,
from the special seed syllable of oneself,
from its light rays, send forth a host of deities
who offer water for the feet and water for the face.
After that, make offerings with the five kinds of offering,
above, below and in the center, each to its own family.
After that, bless the torma
and make offerings to the deities with the Indra mantra:

oṃ inda jama jala jakkha bhūta bahni bau rakṣa canad sujja māda pappa talapātāle aṣṭa sappa svāhā idaṃ biliṃ bhuñja jigha phulla dhūpa māṃsa piṃga ambha sappa kajja sādā khanti khuṇi pheṭa gāda oṃ akāro mukhaṃ sarbadharmāṇāṃ ādyanutpannatvāt oṃ āḥ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā

So that those of lesser intellect may understand,
I have made clear
this Compendium of the Reality of the Torma.
Through this virtue, may minds become virtuous and happy.

The Compendium composed by the master Dharmāpaka is complete.

Translator's Notes

• "The Permanent One" renders □□□□□, which here seems to designate a buddha or family lord, apparently the one who heads the white body family, since the upper white deities are crowned with him in the empowerment; the precise identification is uncertain. Padmanarteśvara is taken as the Sanskrit name behind □□□□□□□□□□, and Pāṇḍaravāsinī behind □□□□□□□□□□. The three tiers correspond to body (white, above), mind (blue, center) and speech (red, below), and the four goddesses with the syllables jaḥ hūṃ baṃ hoḥ are the gatekeeper goddesses (Hook, Noose, Chain, Bell) who summon, draw in, bind and delight the wisdom beings.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.